# What Breaks in Digital Retail Experiences?

This project analyses how large retail platforms balance usability, familiarity, and trust during critical user journeys such as login, product selection, and checkout.

**Type** Internship

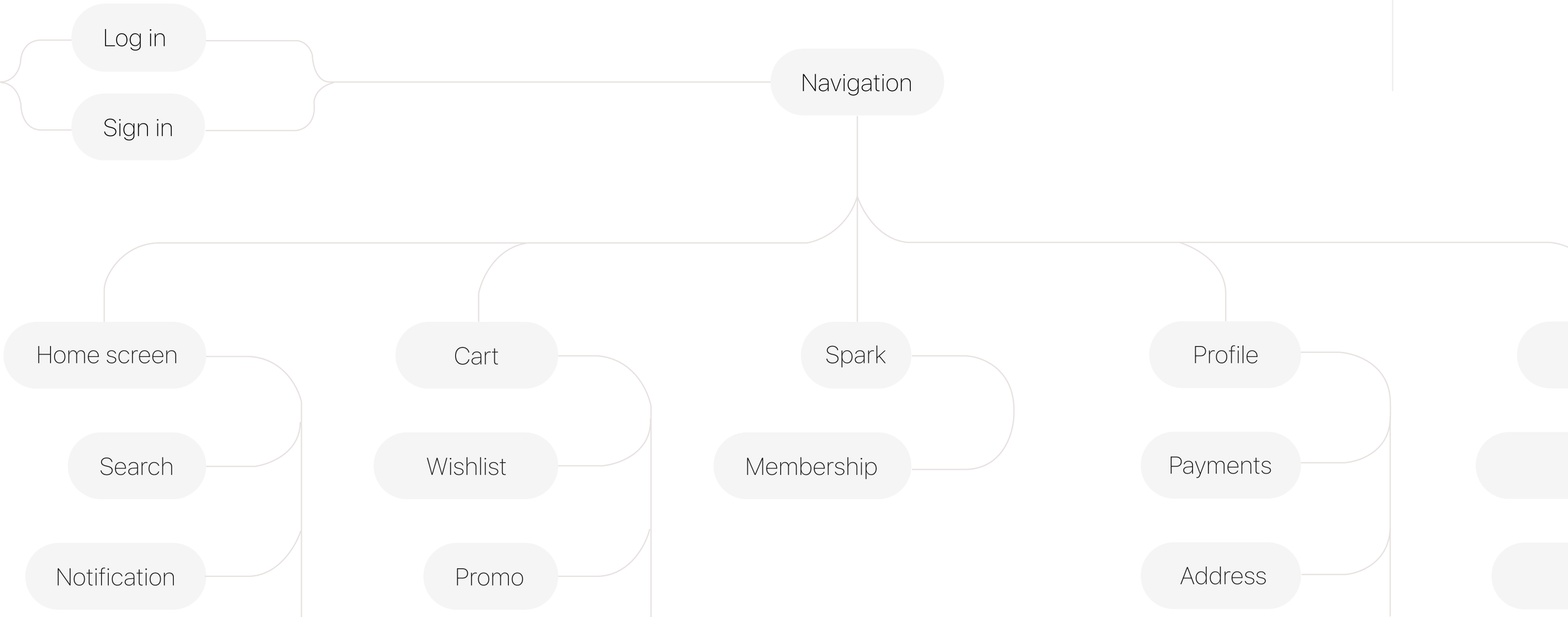
**Time** 4 months

**Team** Individual project



# Where does friction appear in the shopping journey?

# From Discovery to Checkout



| | M&S | ZARA | H&M | UNIQLO | CHARLES & KEITH |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Onboarding | Guest checkout available; text-heavy login | Login deferred until checkout; minimalist UI | Clear CTAs; guest checkout & social login | Account encouraged via member benefits | Clean, premium login; guest checkout allowed |
| Navigation | Deep category structure; information-dense; high cognitive load | Editorial-style, visual-first navigation | Intuitive categories; strong filters & search | Function-based navigation | curated navigation; trend-led |
| Product Page | Very detailed product info, size guides & reviews; cluttered layout | Large immersive imagery; minimal product details | Balanced visuals and information | decision-support focused | Visual-led PDP; minimal text |
| Checkout | Multi-step checkout; clear progress indicator but lengthy flow | Fast, minimal checkoutlacks reassurance and error feedback | Smooth, transparent checkout; strong error prevention | Functional, trust-oriented checkout; clear delivery & returns | Minimal, frictionless checkout; premium micro-interactions |

# Competitive analysis

Competing apps allow users to save items, edit cart selections, and enter the app through both login and sign-up flows, while also providing clear visual confirmation of actions. In contrast, M&S restricts or omits these moments, leading to confusion and reduced confidence during browsing and checkout.

What do users get in other retail apps that they don’t get here?

# What's Breaking the Experience?

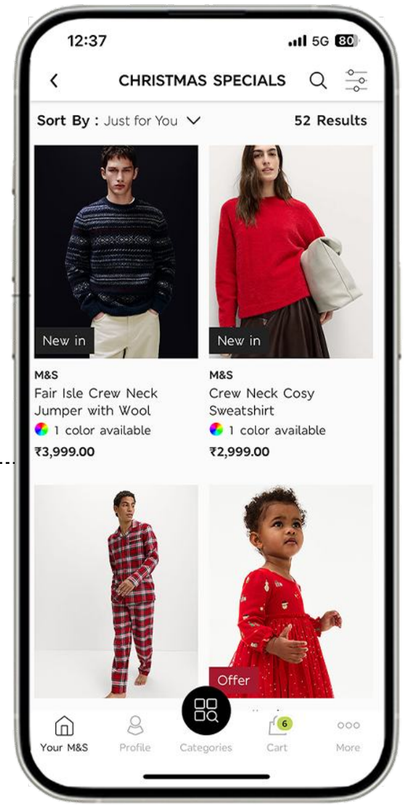



### Forced Login Too Early

Users are asked to log in before they understand the product or the value of the app. This interrupts exploration and creates friction at the very first step.

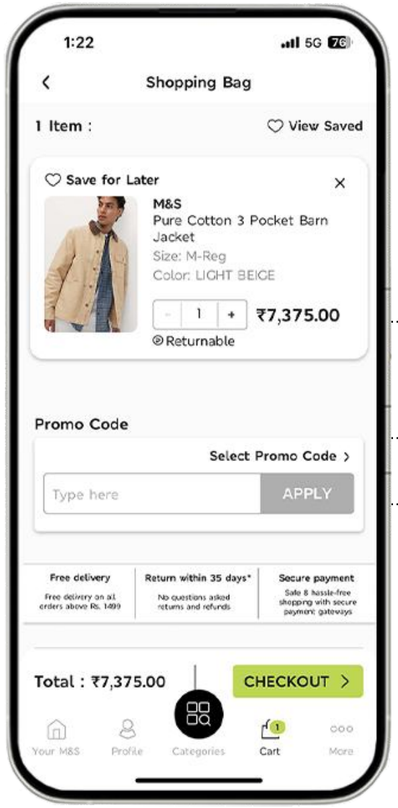
### Product listing pages feel cluttered and unclear.

Product colours are not clearly visible, discount information is missing, and the wishlist icon is hard to find. Prices, labels, and categories compete for attention, making it difficult for users to focus or compare products easily.



# Where Users Struggle Most

While reviewing the cart and checkout flow, a few moments stood out where users slow down or feel unsure. These moments don’t stop the journey completely, but they create hesitation.




## No Easy Edit in Cart

Once items are added to the cart, users have limited control. Basic actions like editing size, quantity, or removing items are not there, forcing users to break the shopping flow.

## Discounts feel hidden

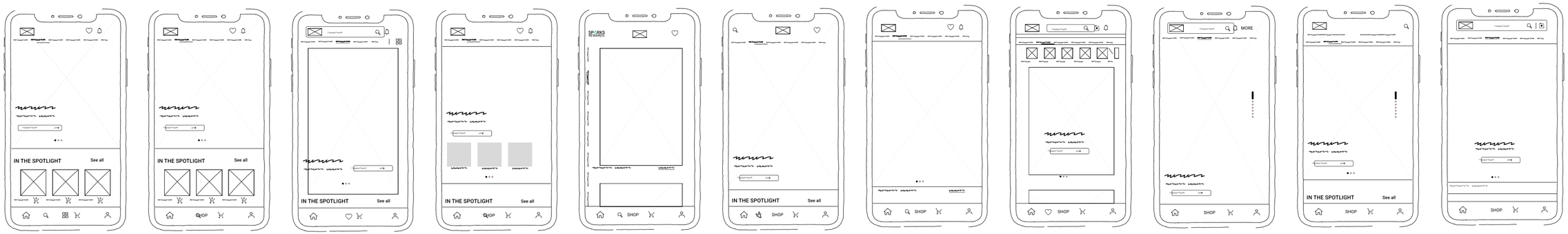
Users don’t clearly see if a discount is applied or available. This creates doubt about whether they are getting the best price.

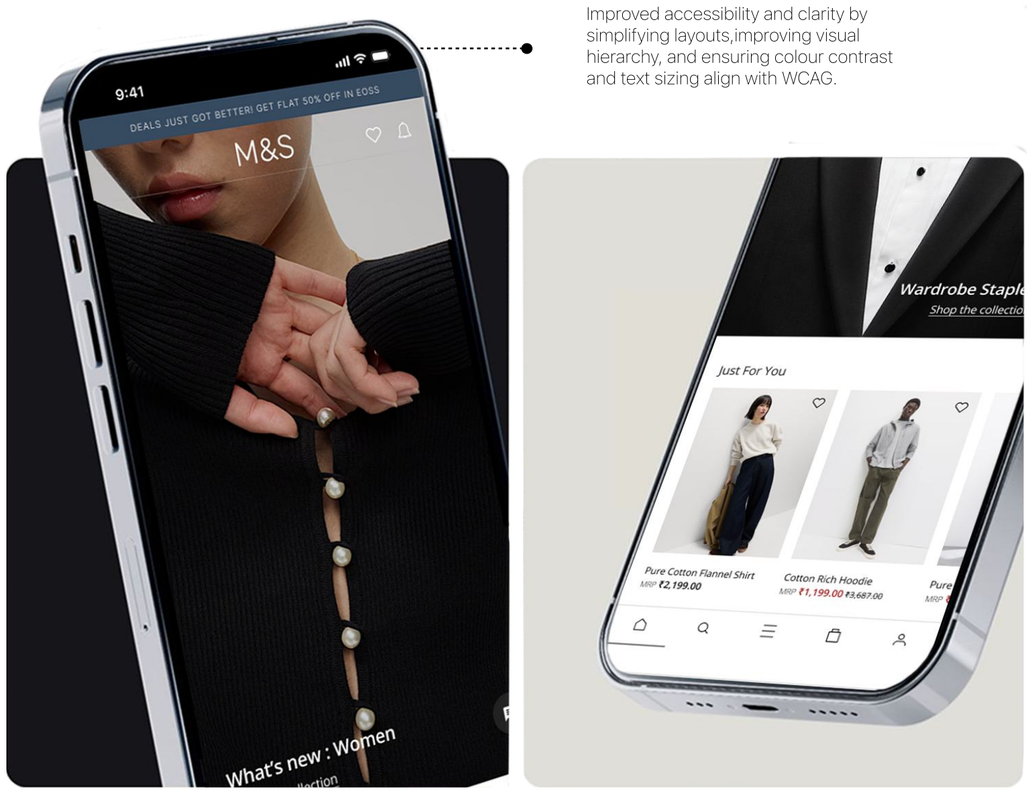
## Checkout lacks reassurance

Before paying, users don’t see enough confirmation about delivery, returns, or flexibility. This makes checkout feel rushed instead of confident.

# Exploring Possible Directions

I used rough sketches to explore different layout directions, information hierarchy, and interaction patterns, allowing for quick iteration before finalising the UI.






# From Observations to Insights

The final UI redesign focused on creating a clear, accessible, and scalable experience for a wide range of users. Core features such as Wishlist visibility and Quick Add were surfaced earlier in the flow to support faster decision-making.

# Key UX Learnings from M&S

Familiar patterns reduce decision anxiety

Consistency builds transactional trust

Visual similarity is not laziness  it's usability

# What this project taught me ?

This project taught me the importance of grounding design decisions in user research rather than assumptions. Working on a real-world product taught me to design for multiple user scenarios and edge cases, not ideal users.I learned new ways of testing flows through rapid prototyping and heuristic analysis, and became more aware of accessibility, cognitive load, and system feedback.